



Warming up: Krishan Pathak in action during Indian men's hockey team's training session at the SAI National Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

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delicate transition from a legendary figure to a new custodian with remarkable ease. Pathak, with 125 caps spanning six years, has had the privilege of learning from the best, ensuring continuity and stability within the group.

"When you've played 125 matches for your country, replacing someone or stepping into their role isn't a problem. You gain a different level of confidence after that. You've played in major tournaments like the World Cup, the Asian Games, and the Asian Champions Trophy," Pathak said.

He continued, "If I were in a different situation, where I hadn't played many games, it would have been very difficult. If a senior player is unavailable and you suddenly have to step in, the team needs to take

responsibility because you lack the necessary experience."

Much credit goes to former coach Graham Reid, who rotated Pathak and Sreejesh across matches and even as rolling substitutions within games, with each playing two quarters per game.

Pathak also advocates for the same approach to be followed in the future. "Junior goalkeepers need to play games to build their confidence. Otherwise, they won't know what situations they'll face or what kind of pressure they'll be under."

Throughout Pathak's career, Sreejesh has been a constant source of inspiration, mentoring him closely. Their relationship, which began during the 2016 Junior World Cup in Uttar Pradesh, where India won gold, has evolved from that of mentor and mentee to close friends.

"When we played the Junior World Cup in 2016, he joined our team in Lucknow. Having a senior player helps you to learn different things. You build confidence and become

more aware of your mistakes," Pathak reflected.

He added, "It's good to have a friendship with someone like that. We used to discuss our mistakes, which was beneficial for both of us."

Big shoes to fill

On the field, Pathak's biggest challenge will be to replicate Sreejesh's dominance in front of the goal. As modern hockey increasingly relies on Penalty Corners (PCs) to score, teams are continually developing new strategies to capitalise on these opportunities.

At Paris 2024, India defended PCs exceptionally well, with Sreejesh earning widespread praise for his crucial saves, particularly during the quarterfinal against Great Britain when the team was reduced to 10 men. Pathak will face similar tests in upcoming tournaments, but he remains confident in his ability to rise to the occasion, supported by a rock-solid PC defensive unit.

"We prepare extensively for the